Faculty Positions in the United States

Zivich Research Group

Faculty Positions

Describe basic structure of academic positions in the United States

Help you to understand structures and career path differences

Academic Tracks

Different institutions have different tracks (or names). At UNC,

- **Tenure**: what you usually think of
- **Research**: primary role is research
- **Clinical**: have clinical duties outside of other roles

Each role entails different responsibilities

Academic Tracks

Differences:

- **Tenure**: research, teaching (expected to teach a set amount of credit hours), service (part of academic committees in department, school, university)
- **Research**: primarily research with fewer obligations to department and university, but expected to have full external coverage of your effort

The following positions are all on one of these tracks

- This determines roles and promotion criteria

Assistant Professor

Entry-level professor position

- First step on the ladder
- Occurs directly after graduation or after a postdoctoral period

Associate Professor

Mid-level professor position

- Next promotion level in academia
- Sometimes jointly given with tenure
- More responsibilities in department

Tenure

- A more permanent position in academia. Quite difficult for a university to dismiss someone who has received tenure

Professor

High-level professor position

- Highest-level generally
- Some variations at this level

Full Professor

- Have voting privileges on department policy and decisions

Others

Adjunct Professor

- Part-time, usually teaching

Distinguished Professor

- Usually have set salary coverage, named by a donor

Professor Emeritus

- Retired, with some access to university resources

Questions?